

Content itself will be increasingly created socially—think more blogs putting up “contribute” buttons. The comments on boards and forums are significant... comments sometimes span pages, and might be even more insightful than the original article.

We’re also seeing niche communities, like those at No.1 Industries, a company that has created *targeted* social networking sites. No.1 Artist, for example, focuses on providing a social network for artists so they can interact with other artists and other such things. It’s just *better* for an artist to be in such a community than, for example, MySpace. Expect to see more of these.

So will we just keep scrapping each other on Orkut, collaborating on documents, and such?

Think about the disparity between who we are online and offline; we all have a persona we like to project online. We have our nicks, our avatars. Now we aren’t isolated in the real world, and we just needn’t be in the online world... we’ll be doing things together, but behind our online personas. Doing what together? Browsing, for one; sharing experiences, for another; sharing bookmarks, for a third. Our point is, there’s no limit. What do you do with your friends *offline*? And isn’t there something online for each thing you can do offline anyway?

A blogger called Joe Marchese had this to say in a recent post: “It’s easy to see a not-too-distant future where everyone has an account for online projection of self, a means by which to edit that projection, and a dashboard for aggregating and organising other social content.” And then: “Picture all the most useful functionality of the Web: the Diggs, the RSS feeds, video, picture and file sharing, search, etc. all blending together through social-network-like interfaces.”

But on another note, is this coming—regulations? So people won’t be able to fake their identities? Have you noticed Amazon’s “Real Name” feature? How that works is, when you want to write reviews and submit photos to Amazon, you elect to identify yourself with your real name. (This is verified by way of the credit card on file.) Could social networks go the same way—requiring you to be who you “really” are? Speculation, but not speculation gone wild. Our take on this is that *some* networks—such as business networks—could go this way, and for good reason.

In the end, what we see is nothing less than the social network becoming the interface between self and world. On a “local” social network, you might well meet more people in six months than you did in the 10 years.

“Outside’s overrated,” as Justin Frankel put it. ☒

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The Network Is...

...the computer. Someone said that a long time ago, and that vision is inching ever closer to fruition

We like blogs, and some are worth quoting. (That’s why we have a “Blog-watch” every month.) Here’s from N F Saunders of the University of Queensland: “Six months ago, I was ‘desktop man.’ I preferred my software locally installed. I wanted complete control of my machine, my desktop applications, my files. All that has changed and the keyword here is ‘synchronisation.’ Or rather, no need for synchronisation. Like many people I use a work computer and a machine at home... If like me you’re a bit slow and don’t get it yet, here’s the soundbite: *everything is in the one place.*”

You can guess the rest; Saunders is typical of those who have moved their apps to online. You can collaborate on stuff by just sending people a URL; you don’t need to bother with synchronisation; hell, you don’t even need to buy expensive software with features you don’t need. The great thing is, these online applications—Google’s apps come to mind first—are getting better.

Web apps are not confined to tasks such as word processing: witness Flex, an online compiler. We’re close to the Death of the Desktop. If we can have online compilers, what is to stop

us from imagining Photoshop online (already in the works, incidentally)? The entire program, with all its features? (Well, paid, of course...) Nothing in the term “personal computing” implies the Desktop: why not online, bandwidth willing? When the UIs are actually better? When they’re mostly free? When they don’t require updates?

That one thought is enough to get you thinking—will *everything* be done online? Here’s a simple thought: we have thin clients and centralised servers—so what about the Net being one large, all-serving server? Not literally, but come to think of it, if there were a Google OS, couldn’t that be a server for all our computers as thin clients?

So let’s see what we do on our computers... we have an OS, we have a hard disk, and we run software. That’s about it. All of it could be shifted online in theory. And in practice, what’s left out is the part where the hardware is important—as in demanding games.

The desktop will become just the connecting device. Recall the “e-mail machines” that once made an entry into the market: all you could do was connect to the Net and retrieve mail. Now extend that, and say you

